‘Sir, I am happy that I am being released soon, but I will be back after killing the man who made me a murderer.’

‘Antony, you are young, you have a life ahead,’ I tried to reason.

‘No sir, nothing can change my resolve. I have to kill him and get back here. Nothing else matters. I have been praying to God to keep him alive till I get out.’

He said he did not want to talk anything more about himself.

THE MAKING OF MAHENDRAGIRI

‘You can’t have the brain in Trivandrum and the hands in Balasore.’

My transfer and the struggle before getting back to the Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre (LPSC) took away not just sixteen months from my association with the Vikas engine and PSLV project, it also came in the midst of our setting up an integrated test facility in Mahendragiri. As the LPSC deputy director, I was hands-on with the Mahendragiri project, starting before my transfer and completing ten months after my return.

The need for a facility to ground test rocket engines and stages occurred to us while putting together the 60-tonne Vikas engine in 1980; before that the largest rocket engine we made was a three-tonner. We could take the first Vikas engine to Vernon for the test, but if we were to make many more engines—which we were sure of doing—we needed an integrated test complex in India.

A ground test involves virtually as much preparation and operation as a rocket launch. Here, we would be testing different components of the engine for different durations to see if all the parameters—thrust, pressure, temperature, specific impulse and many more—are normal so that the engine performs as per our expectation.

An integrated test complex should have test facilities to test components —engine, gas generator, turbo pump—separately and together as a stage.